This fragrant soup is seasoned with a blend of spices often used to give Indian pickles and preserves their distinctive tang. It is best enjoyed with hot naan.

curried broth with peppers

SERVES 4 **PREP** 15 MINS **COOK** 25 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS

2 tbsp vegetable oil
1 star anise
½ tsp hot red pepper flakes
½ tsp nigella seeds
1½ tsp fennel seeds
¼ tsp fenugreek seeds
2 onions, diced
1½in (4cm) piece of ginger, peeled and grated
1 orange bell pepper, diced
1 yellow bell pepper, diced
2 tbsp basmati rice
¾ tsp turmeric
½ tsp garam masala
1 quart (1 liter) hot vegetable stock
1 tbsp palm sugar
grated zest and juice of 1 large lemon
salt and freshly ground black pepper
2 tbsp cilantro, coarsely chopped

1 Heat the oil in a large saucepan over medium heat, add the star anise, pepper flakes, nigella, fennel, and fenugreek, and stir-fry for 30 seconds. Lower the heat, add the onions and ginger, then cover and cook for 5 minutes or until the onions have softened. Stir in the peppers and fry for 2–3 minutes.

2 Add the rice, turmeric, and garam masala, stir well, and cook for 1 minute. Pour in the stock, then add the sugar and lemon zest. Season with salt and freshly ground black pepper, and simmer for 15 minutes or until the soup has thickened slightly and the peppers and rice are tender. Sharpen with the lemon juice and serve garnished with cilantro.

PEPPERS
Look for bright, shiny peppers that feel firm, and avoid any that have soft spots or are pale or shriveled. Yellow and orange bell peppers are ripe versions of green peppers. Because of this, they are sweeter.

